

Two Concepts of Liberty



The concept of liberty as the freedom of individuals to go about their lives, so long as this harms no one else, was taken almost for granted until the mid-20th century. But in his *Two Concepts of Liberty* (1958), Isaiah Berlin explained that what we generally call liberty is *negative* freedom, freedom from external interference. What he called *positive* freedom, on the other hand, comes from within, from having the resources to achieve personal autonomy and realize one's own potential. While negative freedom is defined by our interaction with others, positive freedom is concerned with personal development, though it can be fostered by recognition and

participation in a positive social context. Berlin believed both negative and positive freedoms are valuable, but that positive freedom carries dangers. People with personal positive freedom can become tyrannical, as happened to Robespierre in post-revolutionary France. The result is freedom only for the powerful – as Berlin puts it: ‘In a lake stocked with minnows and minnow-eating pike, freedom for the pike means death to the minnows.’